

MOMENTUM & 8TH NOTE FEEL

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #62

When you hear great jazz, you are certainly moved by the player's tone, and by the notes that they play - their melodic and harmonic conception. All that said, one of the most important things that we react to when listening to music is the FEEL of the player and the music. HOW the music is being played (as opposed to WHAT is being played). The "how" part in jazz is incredibly important. Jazz has a particular feel, and a huge element of that jazz feel is 8th notes motion, and 8th note MOMENTUM.

Look at most jazz books, jazz videos, or even most university jazz programs, and you'll see that 95% of the discussion is regarding chords and scales, voicings and rhythms, harmonic substitutions and melodic devices. All great stuff, but where is the discussion on FEEL, which is so central to the jazz experience? Well, it's REALLY hard to teach and talk about this concept. As a result, most of us are just given the advice to "listen to a lot of jazz." Well, here's the thing . . . you've probably listened to *thousands of hours of jazz* already. How did that work for you??!! Not terribly effective, I'm guessing.

WHAT TO DO

- Pick a tonality or scale (ie. C major or A mixolydian). Something "easy."
- Improvise RANDOMLY around that tonality in solid 8th notes. No rests, ever.
- Do this for a minimum of 5 minutes a day. 10 minutes is better.
- Focus on the 8th note motion, and only the quality of the 8th notes. How you are moving from note to note. The quality of the motion.
- Change tempos if you like, but only after a few minutes of one tempo.
- Aim for evenness and momentum. The QUALITY of the 8th notes.

WHAT NOT TO DO

- Don't think about the pitches. Don't "plan your notes" or your melody. Allow yourself wrong notes. DO NOT CARE about the pitches. This exercise is about 8th notes.
- *This exercise has NOTHING to do with pitches.* If you are thinking about C or C#, or a Charlie Parker lick, or scales in thirds, you are not doing the exercise. 8th notes.
- No rests, except to breath. You are not allowed to play an 8th rest (in the context of this exercise) until six months from today. Eight 8th notes per measure.